

OUTLINE

FORGIVING LIKE JOSEPH: SEEING GOD'S PURPOSE BEHIND OUR PAIN

OPENING

A young man who experienced something very painful. He was betrayed, rejected, and hurt by the people closest to him. His own brothers hated him, threw him into a pit, and sold him as a slave.

His name was Joseph.

Joseph had every reason to hate his brothers. But instead of choosing revenge, Joseph chose forgiveness.

Why?

Because Joseph understood something greater than his pain. He understood God's purpose.

Today, from Genesis 45:1-8, we will learn three important truths about forgiveness from Joseph's life.

The title of my message is: "Forgiving Like Joseph: Seeing God's Purpose Behind Our Pain."

Point 1: Forgiveness Begins When We Remember God's Presence (Genesis 45:5)

Genesis 45:5 says:

"And now, do not be distressed or angry with yourselves because you sold me here, for God sent me before you to preserve life."

Joseph did not deny his pain. His brothers really did hurt him. They really sold him as a slave. They really caused him suffering.

But Joseph saw a bigger picture. He understood that although his brothers had bad intentions, God was still working through the situation.

Joseph remembered that God was with him: when he was in the pit, when he was sold as a slave, when he was falsely accused, and when he was in prison. **His circumstances changed, but God's presence never changed.**

When we focus only on our pain, our hearts become filled with anger, but when we remember God's presence, we can say: "God is still with me. God has not forgotten me."

Forgiveness starts when we remember that God is bigger than our problems.

Point 2: Forgiveness Comes When We Understand God's Purpose (Genesis 45:7)

Genesis 45:7 says:

"God sent me before you to preserve for you a remnant on earth and to save your lives by a great deliverance."

Joseph understood that his suffering had a purpose.

God was preparing Joseph for something greater. The pit was not the end. The slavery was not the end. The prison was not the end. God was preparing Joseph to become a leader who would save many lives during the famine.

Joseph did not see his suffering as meaningless. He saw it as part of God's plan.

Romans 8:28 reminds us:

"And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love Him."

Notice it does not say all things are good. It says God works through all things for good. The pain may be real, but God's purpose is greater.

Point 3: Forgiveness Reflects the Heart of God (Genesis 45:14-15)

After Joseph revealed himself, he embraced his brothers and wept over them.

Genesis 45:15 says:

"And he kissed all his brothers and wept over them. Afterward his brothers talked with him."

Joseph did not only speak forgiveness. He showed forgiveness. He restored his relationship with his brothers.

This reminds us of Jesus Christ. Jesus showed the greatest example of forgiveness. As followers of Christ, we are called not only to receive forgiveness but also to forgive others.

Forgiveness does not mean saying that what someone did was right.

Forgiveness means:

"I release my desire for revenge and trust God to handle justice."

Forgiveness frees our hearts from bitterness.

CONCLUSION

Joseph's story teaches us three important lessons:

First, forgiveness begins when we remember God's presence. God is with us even when people hurt us.

Second, forgiveness comes when we understand God's purpose. God can use our pain for His greater plan.

Third, forgiveness reflects the heart of God. Because God has forgiven us, we can forgive others.

Remember Joseph.

The same God who was with Joseph in the pit was with him in the palace. And the same God who helped Joseph forgive is the God who can help us forgive.